大熊猫回家

教一只熊猫忘记人类

Bringing the Pandas Home

Teaching a panda to forget us

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 5 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 四川[†]的山里，早上常常有雾[‡]。雾慢慢散开的时候，你也许会看见一只大熊猫从竹林里走出来，走得很慢，很小心。可是如果你再仔细看一看，就会发现这只“熊猫”有点儿奇怪：它是站着走路的，手里还提着一个装满竹子的篮子。它不是熊猫，而是一个穿着熊猫衣服的人。她叫杨帆[§]，今年二十九岁，是卧龙[¶]核桃坪[*]大熊猫野化[#]培训基地的研究人员。

穿熊猫衣服的人

2 第一次穿上这套衣服的时候，杨帆觉得自己像在演一个儿童节目。衣服又厚又重，头套上只有两个小小的洞，夏天穿着它在山上走一圈，里面的衬衫全湿了。更让她难以接受的是衣服上的味道。

† 四川 *Sìchuān* Sichuan province
‡ 雾 *wù* fog, mist
§ 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
¶ 卧龙 *Wòlóng* Wolong, panda reserve in Sichuan
* 核桃坪 *Hétáopíng* Hetaoping, panda training base at Wolong
野化 *yěhuà* rewilding, wild training

In the mountains of Sichuan there is often mist in the morning. As the mist 1
slowly lifts, you might see a giant panda come out of the bamboo grove, walking slowly and carefully. But if you look more closely, you will notice that this "panda" is a little odd: it walks upright, and it is carrying a basket full of bamboo. It is not a panda at all, but a person in a panda suit. Her name is Yang Fan. She is twenty-nine, and she is a researcher at the giant panda wild-training base at Hetaoping in Wolong.

The People in Panda Suits

The first time she put on the suit, Yang Fan felt as if she were performing in 2
a children's show. It was thick and heavy, the head had only two tiny eyeholes, and after one walk around the mountainside in summer the shirt underneath was soaked through. What she found even harder to accept was the smell.

为了让熊猫闻不出人的味道，大家会把熊猫的粪便[1]擦在衣服上。“这也太臭了吧！”她大声说。

老马[2]在基地工作了二十多年，是这里最有经验的饲养员[3]。他一边帮她拉好背后的衣服，一边笑着说：“臭就对了。你闻起来越像熊猫，草草[4]就越不会注意你。”“可我是来研究熊猫的，不是来演熊猫的。”“在这里，这两件事是一样的。”老马说，“咱们的工作，就是让她忘了世界上还有人。”

草草是一只一岁多的母[5]熊猫。她从出生起就跟着妈妈生活在一个很大的训练场里，那里有真的山坡[6]、真的竹林和小河。按照计划，她要在这里学习野外[7]生存的本领，大约一年以后被放归[8]到真正的森林里。

1 粪便 *fènbiàn* dung, droppings
2 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper
3 饲养员 *sìyǎngyuán* animal keeper
4 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
5 母 *mǔ* female (animal)
6 山坡 *shānpō* hillside
7 野外 *yěwài* the wild
8 放归 *fàngguī* to release into the wild

So that the pandas could not smell humans, everyone rubbed panda dung onto the suits. "This stinks!" she said loudly. 2

Lao Ma had worked at the base for more than twenty years and was its most experienced keeper. As he straightened the back of her suit, he laughed: "Stinking is the point. The more you smell like a panda, the less Caocao will notice you." "But I came here to study pandas, not to play one." "Here, those are the same thing," said Lao Ma. "Our job is to make her forget that people exist." 3

Caocao was a female panda, a little over a year old. Since birth she had lived with her mother in a huge training enclosure with real hillsides, real bamboo groves and a stream. According to the plan, she would learn the skills of survival in the wild here, and in about a year she would be released into a real forest. 4

所以，饲养员[1]们给她送竹子、检查身体的时候，都必须穿上熊猫衣服，而且不能说话。一旦她习惯了人，觉得人会给她吃的，放归[2]以后就可能主动走到村子和公路附近，那会非常危险。

杨帆[3]刚来的时候，对这些规定很不理解。她从小就喜欢熊猫，大学学的专业也和野生[4]动物保护有关[5]。她心里一直有一个画面：自己坐在熊猫旁边，轻轻地摸它的头。可是在这里，她连跟草草[6]说一句“早上好”都不行。有一次，草草在树下打滚，样子可爱极了，杨帆忍不住笑出了声，老马[7]马上回头看了她一眼。那天晚上，她在日记里写道：“我离熊猫这么近，却好像离她很远。”

1 饲养员 *sìyǎngyuán* animal keeper
2 放归 *fàngguī* to release into the wild
3 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
4 野生 *yěshēng* wild
5 有关 *yǒuguān* to be related to
6 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
7 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper

So whenever the keepers brought her bamboo or gave her a check-up, they had to wear panda suits, and they were not allowed to speak. Once she got used to people and thought they would give her food, she might wander up to villages and roads after her release, and that would be very dangerous. 4

When Yang Fan first arrived, she did not understand these rules at all. She had loved pandas since she was little, and at university she had studied wildlife conservation. She had always carried a picture in her mind: herself sitting beside a panda, gently stroking its head. But here she could not even say "good morning" to Caocao. Once, when Caocao was rolling about under a tree, looking adorable, Yang Fan could not help laughing out loud, and Lao Ma turned round at once and gave her a look. That night she wrote in her diary: "I am so close to a panda, and yet she seems so far away." 5

学会[1]害怕

6 野生[2]的熊猫看起来很温和，但森林并不温和。豹子[3]和野狗[4]会攻击[5]小熊猫；村子、公路和人带来的危险也一直存在。在基地出生的熊猫没有见过这些，因而不知道什么应该怕。研究人员要做的，就是教会草草[6]害怕。

7 这种训练听起来有点儿残酷[7]。有一天，老马[8]和杨帆[9]把一只做得很像的假豹子放在训练场的一棵树下，又用音箱放出豹子的叫声。草草本来在树下吃竹子，听到声音以后先是呆住了，然后飞快地爬上了树，在最高的地方待了一个下午。她的妈妈一直守在树下，冲着假豹子大声地叫。杨帆在电脑前看着，心里很难受。“她吓坏了。”“吓坏了才好。”老马说，“在山里，不会害怕的熊猫活不长。”

1 学会 *xuéhuì* to learn
2 野生 *yěshēng* wild
3 豹子 *bàozi* leopard
4 野狗 *yěgǒu* wild dog
5 攻击 *gōngjī* to attack
6 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
7 残酷 *cánkù* cruel
8 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper
9 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher

Learning to Be Afraid

Wild pandas look gentle, but the forest is not. Leopards and wild dogs at- 6
tack young pandas, and the dangers brought by villages, roads and people are always there. Pandas born at the base have never seen any of this, and so they do not know what to be afraid of. The researchers' job was to teach Caocao fear.

This kind of training sounds a little cruel. One day Lao Ma and Yang Fan 7
put a lifelike model leopard under a tree in the enclosure and played leopard calls through a loudspeaker. Caocao had been eating bamboo under the tree. When she heard the sound she froze for a moment, then shot up the tree and stayed at the very top all afternoon. Her mother stood guard under the tree the whole time, roaring at the fake leopard. Yang Fan watched on the computer with a heavy heart. "She's terrified." "Terrified is good," said Lao Ma. "In the mountains, a panda that can't be afraid doesn't live long."

8 草草[1]戴着一个GPS项圈[2]，以便研究人员随时知道她在哪里、走了多远。每天晚上，杨帆[3]都要把这些数据下载到电脑里，加以整理和分析。她发现草草每天活动的范围越来越大，爬树的时间越来越长，也开始自己挑竹子最好吃的部分吃。有一次，她的项圈被一棵小树给挂住了，她用前脚拉了半天，最后自己弄了下来。随着秋天的到来，她的毛也变得又厚又亮。

9 不过，能不能放归[4]，并不是只看熊猫自己，山里的竹子也很重要。大熊猫每天要花十几个小时吃竹子，一天能吃掉十几公斤甚至更多。而有些竹子每隔几十年就会大面积开花，开完花以后就成片地死去。上世纪八十年代，四川[5]一些地方的箭竹[6]开花死了，不少熊猫因而找不到吃的。所以，选择放归地点以前，研究人员必须对那里的竹子、水和野生[7]熊猫的数量加以调查。

1 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
2 项圈 *xiàngquān* collar
3 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
4 放归 *fàngguī* to release into the wild
5 四川 *Sìchuān* Sichuan province
6 箭竹 *jiànzhú* arrow bamboo
7 野生 *yěshēng* wild

Caocao wore a GPS collar so that the researchers would know at any moment where she was and how far she had walked. Every evening Yang Fan downloaded the data to her computer, sorted it and analysed it. She found that Caocao's daily range was growing, she spent longer and longer in the trees, and she had begun choosing the tastiest parts of the bamboo for herself. Once her collar got caught on a small tree; she pulled at it with her front paws for ages and finally freed herself. As autumn came on, her coat grew thick and glossy. 8

But whether a panda can be released does not depend on the panda alone; the bamboo in the mountains matters too. A giant panda spends more than ten hours a day eating bamboo and can get through more than ten kilos in a day, or even more. And some kinds of bamboo flower over wide areas once every few decades, and after flowering they die off in great stretches. In the 1980s, arrow bamboo flowered and died in parts of Sichuan, and many pandas were left with nothing to eat. So before choosing a release site, researchers have to survey the bamboo, the water and the number of wild pandas there. 9

10 一天晚上，杨帆[1]问老马[2]：“野外[3]已经有那么多熊猫了，为什么还要把草草[4]放回去？”老马指着墙上的地图说：“你看，这些绿色的地方都是熊猫生活的森林，可是它们让公路、村子和农田[5]给切成了一小块一小块。每一块里的熊猫都不多，互相难以见面，时间长了，小熊猫就会越来越弱。我们放归[6]熊猫，又在森林之间修‘走廊’[7]，就是为了让它们重新连起来。”杨帆看着地图上那些小小的绿色，第一次觉得，草草身上的任务比她想象的大得多。

放归

11 第二年秋天，草草两岁半了。经过一次又一次的检查和评估，专家们终于决定：可以放归了。

1 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
2 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper
3 野外 *yěwài* the wild
4 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
5 农田 *nóngtián* farmland
6 放归 *fàngguī* to release into the wild
7 走廊 *zǒuláng* (wildlife) corridor

One evening Yang Fan asked Lao Ma, "There are already so many pandas in 10
the wild. Why do we still need to send Caocao back?" Lao Ma pointed to the map on the wall. "Look, these green patches are all forest where pandas live, but roads, villages and farmland have cut them into little pieces. There aren't many pandas in each piece, and they can hardly ever meet. Over time the cubs grow weaker and weaker. We release pandas and build 'corridors' between the forests to join them up again." Looking at those little green patches on the map, Yang Fan felt for the first time that the task resting on Caocao was far bigger than she had imagined.

The Release

The following autumn, Caocao was two and a half. After one check and 11
assessment after another, the experts finally decided that she was ready.

11 放归[†]地点选在离基地很远的一个自然保护区[‡]，那里竹子长得好，也有一小群野生[§]熊猫。

12 出发前一天晚上，杨帆[¶]一直难以入睡。她打开电脑，一张一张地看草草[*]的照片：刚出生时只有一百多克、全身红红的小东西；第一次爬树时紧紧抱着树干的样子；吃竹子吃得满脸都是竹叶的样子。她突然有点儿害怕。在基地里，草草每天都在摄像头下面，生病了有医生，没有竹子了有人送。到了山里，这一切都没有了。

13 “你说，她会不会恨我们？”第二天早上在车上，她小声问老马[#]。老马看着窗外，过了很久才说：“她不会记得我们的。这就是我们这么多年想要的结果。”

14 保护区的路很不好走，最后一段车开不上去，十几个人只好抬着装草草的大箱子往上走。

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† 放归 *fàngguī* to release into the wild
‡ 保护区 *bǎohùqū* (nature) reserve
§ 野生 *yěshēng* wild
¶ 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
* 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
\# 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper

The release site was a nature reserve far from the base, where the bamboo grew well and there was a small group of wild pandas. 11

The night before they set off, Yang Fan could not get to sleep. She opened her computer and looked through Caocao's photos one by one: the little pink thing weighing just over a hundred grams at birth; the way she clung to the trunk the first time she climbed a tree; her face covered in bamboo leaves as she ate. Suddenly she felt a little afraid. At the base Caocao was under the cameras every day; if she fell ill there was a doctor, and if she ran out of bamboo someone brought more. In the mountains, none of that would exist. 12

"Do you think she'll hate us?" she asked Lao Ma quietly in the car the next morning. Lao Ma looked out of the window for a long time before he answered. "She won't remember us. That's the result we've wanted all these years." 13

The roads in the reserve were rough and the cars could not get up the last stretch, so a dozen or so people had to carry Caocao's big crate uphill. 14

14 到了地点，大家退到远处，箱子的门打开了。草草[†]没有马上出来。她先把头伸出来，闻了闻空气，又把头收了回去。过了好几分钟，她才慢慢地走出箱子，在地上闻了一会儿，然后头也不回地走进了竹林。前后不到十分钟，她就叫密密的竹子给挡住了，再也看不见了。有人鼓掌，有人拍照。杨帆[‡]没有动。她发现自己的眼睛湿了，可她不知道这是因为高兴，还是因为难过。

没有信号

15 放归[§]以后的头两个月，一切都很顺利。项圈[¶]每天按时发回数据，显示草草在一片两千多米高的森林里活动，范围慢慢扩大。红外[*]相机还拍到过她几次：一次在小河边喝水，一次在一棵倒在地上的大树上睡觉。

† 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
‡ 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
§ 放归 *fàngguī* to release into the wild
¶ 项圈 *xiàngquān* collar
* 红外 *hóngwài* infrared

At the site, everyone moved back to a distance, and the crate door was opened. 14
Caocao did not come out at once. First she put her head out, sniffed the air, and pulled back in again. Only after several minutes did she slowly walk out of the crate, sniff the ground for a while, and then walk into the bamboo without looking back. In less than ten minutes, she was hidden by the dense bamboo and could no longer be seen. Some people clapped, some took photos. Yang Fan did not move. She found that her eyes were wet, but she did not know whether it was from happiness or from sadness.

No Signal

For the first two months after the release, everything went smoothly. The 15
collar sent back data on time every day, showing that Caocao was moving about in a forest more than two thousand metres up, and that her range was slowly growing. Infrared cameras caught her a few times as well: once drinking at a stream, once asleep on a fallen tree.

15 研究人员把这些照片和她在基地时的照片加以比较，发现她瘦了一点儿，但精神很好。

16 随着冬天的到来，山里开始下雪。十二月的一天早上，杨帆[†]像平时一样打开电脑，却发现草草[‡]的数据停在了三天前，最后一个位置在一条山沟附近。之后，什么也没有了。

17 “可能是项圈[§]的电池出问题了。天太冷，电池容易坏。”一个同事说。“也可能是信号被大山给挡住了。”另[¶]一个同事说，“先把最后几天的数据调出来，加以分析吧。”大家都在找技术上的原因，可是每个人心里都清楚，还有一种可能：草草出事[*]了。

18 杨帆想起了一件事。

† 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
‡ 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
§ 项圈 *xiàngquān* collar
¶ 另 *lìng* another
* 出事 *chūshì* to have an accident

The researchers compared these photos with the ones from the base and found that she was a little thinner, but in good spirits. 15

As winter arrived, snow began to fall in the mountains. One morning in December, Yang Fan opened her computer as usual and found that Caocao's data had stopped three days earlier; the last position was near a ravine. After that, there was nothing. 16

"Maybe the collar battery's failed. It's very cold, and batteries die easily," one colleague said. "Or the signal might be blocked by the mountains," said another. "Let's pull up the last few days of data and analyse them first." Everyone was looking for a technical reason, but each of them knew there was another possibility: something had happened to Caocao. 17

Yang Fan remembered something. 18

18 大约二十年前，中国第一只人工繁殖[1]后放归[2]的大熊猫祥祥[3]，在野外[4]生活了不到一年就死了。研究人员认为，它很可能是在跟野生[5]熊猫争地盘的时候受了伤。后来，大家对训练和放归的方法加以改进，也更多地选择放归母[6]熊猫。可是，谁也不能保证悲剧不会再发生。

19 那天晚上，杨帆[7]一个人坐在办公室里，看着地图上那个不再移动的小点。她突然觉得，也许当初就不应该让她走。如果草草[8]还在基地，至少是安全的。老马[9]走进来，把一杯热茶放在她面前。“明天上山。”他说。“雪这么大，能找到吗？”“找不到也得找。”

1 繁殖 *fánzhí* to breed
2 放归 *fàngguī* to release into the wild
3 祥祥 *Xiángxiáng* Xiangxiang, first captive-bred panda released (2006)
4 野外 *yěwài* the wild
5 野生 *yěshēng* wild
6 母 *mǔ* female (animal)
7 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
8 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
9 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper

About twenty years earlier, Xiangxiang, the first captive-bred giant panda 18
China had released, died after less than a year in the wild. Researchers believed he had most likely been injured fighting wild pandas over territory. Afterwards, the methods of training and release were improved, and more female pandas were chosen for release. Still, no one could promise that such a tragedy would never happen again.

That night Yang Fan sat alone in the office, staring at the little dot on the 19
map that no longer moved. Suddenly she felt that perhaps they should never have let her go. If Caocao were still at the base, at least she would be safe. Lao Ma came in and put a cup of hot tea in front of her. "We go up the mountain tomorrow," he said. "With this much snow, can we find her?" "Even if we can't, we have to look."

雪地里的脚印[†]

20 第二天天还没亮，搜索小组就出发了。一共五个人，带着信号接收器、帐篷[‡]和三天的干粮。山上的雪比他们想的还要厚，有的地方雪很深，走起来很累。杨帆[§]每走一步都要先用脚试一试，看看雪下面是石头还是空的。她难以想象，草草[¶]一个人是怎么在这样的地方过冬的。

21 他们先去了最后一个信号出现的山沟。那里很安静，只有风吹过竹林的声音。竹子让厚厚的雪给压弯了腰，有的已经断了。老马[*]在雪地上仔细地看了很久。“没有血，也看不出打斗过。”他说，“这是好消息。”

22 第一天，他们什么也没找到。晚上，大家挤在帐篷里，外面的风大得好像要把帐篷吹走。

† 脚印 *jiǎoyìn* footprint
‡ 帐篷 *zhàngpeng* tent
§ 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
¶ 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
* 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper

Footprints in the Snow

The next day, before it was light, the search team set off. There were five of them, with a signal receiver, tents and three days' food. The snow on the mountain was even deeper than they had expected; in places it was so deep that walking was exhausting. At every step Yang Fan first tested the snow with her foot to see whether there was rock underneath or nothing at all. She could hardly imagine how Caocao was getting through the winter alone in a place like this. 20

First they went to the ravine where the last signal had come from. It was very quiet there; there was only the sound of wind in the bamboo. The bamboo had been bent double by the thick snow, and some of it had snapped. Lao Ma studied the snow carefully for a long time. "No blood, and no sign of a fight," he said. "That's good news." 21

On the first day they found nothing. At night they all squeezed into the tents, and the wind outside was so strong it seemed about to blow the tents away. 22

22 杨帆[1]冷得睡不着，小声说：“马师傅，我是不是错了？以前我一直觉得放归[2]是对的，可现在我只想把她找回来，带回基地，再也不让她走了。”

23 老马[3]在黑暗中沉默了一会儿。“我刚工作的时候，也有过一只熊猫。我天天喂它，它见了我就跑过来抱我的腿。后来，它一辈子都没有离开过基地，因为它已经离不开人了。”他停了一下，又说：“你说，那是爱它，还是害了它？”杨帆没有回答。她闭[4]上眼睛，听着外面的风声。

24 第二天中午，他们在一片向阳的山坡[5]上发现了一串[6]脚印[7]。脚印又圆又大，旁边还有一些咬断的竹子和新鲜的粪便[8]。老马拿起一块粪便，看了看，又闻了闻。“新鲜的，不超过两天。里面的竹子咬得很碎，说明她吃得不错。”

1 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
2 放归 *fàngguī* to release into the wild
3 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper
4 闭 *bì* to close
5 山坡 *shānpō* hillside
6 串 *chuàn* string, line
7 脚印 *jiǎoyìn* footprint
8 粪便 *fènbiàn* dung, droppings

Yang Fan was too cold to sleep. She whispered, "Master Ma, was I wrong? I always thought releasing her was right, but now all I want is to find her, bring her back to the base, and never let her go again." 22

Lao Ma was silent in the dark for a while. "When I first started working, I had a panda too. I fed him every day, and whenever he saw me he ran over and hugged my leg. He never left the base for the rest of his life, because he couldn't live without people any more." He paused, then said, "Tell me, was that loving him, or harming him?" Yang Fan did not answer. She closed her eyes and listened to the wind outside. 23

At noon on the second day, they found a line of footprints on a sunny slope. The prints were big and round, and nearby there was some bitten-off bamboo and fresh dung. Lao Ma picked up a piece of dung, looked at it and sniffed it. "Fresh, no more than two days old. The bamboo in it is chewed fine, which means she's eating well." 24

25 可是，脚印†没走多远，就在一片乱石头中间消失了。他们又找了一个下午，一直到天快黑了，雪又开始下起来。这些粪便‡被带回了基地，可是要确认是不是草草§的，必须做DNA检测，至少要等好几天。老马¶说："如果是她，就说明她还活着，自己能找到吃的，只是项圈*坏了。"杨帆#点了点头。她第一次觉得，找不到草草，也许不是坏消息。

春天

26 一个星期以后，DNA的结果出来了：粪便确实是草草的。整个冬天，研究人员又上了两次山，在不同的地方找到了她的脚印和吃剩的竹子，可是一直没有真正见到她。天气慢慢变暖，山上的雪一天比一天少，小河里的水一天比一天多。

† 脚印 *jiǎoyìn* footprint
‡ 粪便 *fènbiàn* dung, droppings
§ 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
¶ 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma ("Old Ma"), a keeper
* 项圈 *xiàngquān* collar
\# 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher

But the footprints did not go far before they disappeared among a jumble of rocks. They searched for another whole afternoon, until it was nearly dark and snow began to fall again. The dung was taken back to the base, but to confirm whether they were Caocao's, a DNA test was needed, and that would take several days at least. Lao Ma said, "If it's her, it means she's alive and can find food on her own, and it's just the collar that's broken." Yang Fan nodded. For the first time she felt that not being able to find Caocao might not be bad news. 25

Spring

A week later the DNA result came back: the dung really was Caocao's. Over the winter the researchers went up the mountain twice more and found her footprints and half-eaten bamboo in different places, but they never saw her with their own eyes. The weather slowly grew warmer, the snow on the mountain shrank day by day, and the streams grew fuller day by day. 26

27 四月的一天，杨帆[1]在整理红外[2]相机的照片时，突然停了下来。照片是在夜里拍的，有点儿模糊，但是能看清楚：一只大熊猫正站在一棵大树旁边，项圈[3]也还在。是草草[4]！她看起来比秋天时还胖了一些。

28 杨帆点开下一张照片，又吓了一跳。在草草身后几米远的地方，还有一只熊猫。它的个子更大，身上没有项圈。“马师傅！您快来看！”她喊了起来。老马[5]走过来，戴上眼镜，看了很久，慢慢地笑了。“野生[6]的，公[7]的。”他说，“春天正是熊猫找对象的季节。”

29 办公室里一下子热闹起来，大家围在电脑前，把那几张照片看了一遍又一遍。有人说，要是草草将来能在野外[8]生下小熊猫，那片森林里的熊猫群就会多一些新的血液[9]，因而变得更健康。

1 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
2 红外 *hóngwài* infrared
3 项圈 *xiàngquān* collar
4 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
5 老马 *Lǎo Mǎ* Lao Ma (“Old Ma”), a keeper
6 野生 *yěshēng* wild
7 公 *gōng* male (animal)
8 野外 *yěwài* the wild
9 血液 *xuèyè* blood

One day in April, Yang Fan was sorting through photos from the infrared cameras when she suddenly stopped. The photo had been taken at night and was a little blurry, but it was clear enough: a giant panda was standing beside a big tree, and the collar was still there. It was Caocao! She looked even plumper than she had in the autumn. 27

Yang Fan clicked open the next photo and jumped again. A few metres behind Caocao was another panda. It was bigger, and it wore no collar. "Master Ma! Come and look, quick!" she shouted. Lao Ma came over, put on his glasses and looked for a long time, and slowly he smiled. "A wild one. A male," he said. "Spring is just the season when pandas look for a mate." 28

All at once the office came alive; everyone crowded round the computer and looked at those few photos again and again. Someone said that if Caocao could one day give birth to a cub in the wild, the panda group in that forest would gain some new blood and so become healthier. 29

29 也有人说，现在高兴还太早，一切都要等以后的数据来证明。

30 晚上，杨帆[†]又打开了日记本。她想起第一次穿熊猫衣服时的那种臭味，想起草草[‡]走出箱子时头也不回的样子，想起雪地里那一串[§]圆圆的脚印[¶]。她曾经以为，保护一只熊猫，就是让她离自己近一点儿，再近一点儿。现在她终于明白了：有的时候，保护就是学会[*]放手，让她走得远远[#]的，远到再也不需要我们。她在日记的最后写道："草草，你不会记得我。没关系。欢迎回家。"

† 杨帆 *Yáng Fān* Yang Fan, a young researcher
‡ 草草 *Cǎocǎo* Caocao, a young female panda
§ 串 *chuàn* string, line
¶ 脚印 *jiǎoyìn* footprint
* 学会 *xuéhuì* to learn
\# 远远 *yuǎnyuǎn* far away

Others said it was too early to celebrate; everything would have to be proved by future data. 29

That evening Yang Fan opened her diary again. She remembered the stink the first time she wore the panda suit, the way Caocao had walked out of the crate without looking back, and that line of round footprints in the snow. She had once thought that protecting a panda meant bringing her closer and closer to herself. Now at last she understood: sometimes protecting means learning to let go, letting her go far, far away, so far that she will never need us again. At the end of the entry she wrote: "Caocao, you won't remember me. That's all right. Welcome home." 30